

therapy on an ongoing basis. In the meantime, I want you both to hear that I'm tracking what a painful time this is. And I hear that you could use help.



This is just one example of how an initial IFIO session might go. Every couple and every therapist are different. We encourage you to continue using any assessment tools you value and to find your own way of introducing the IFIO concepts while staying open, curious, and connected to the couple.

PHASE 2 OF TREATMENT: GETTING TO THE HEART OF THE MATTER

Tracking the Sequences of the Couple's Conflict

Salvador Minuchin, a family therapist in the late twentieth century, developed the strategy of *tracking* as a means of exploring negative interactions in families (Minuchin & Fishman, 1981). Similarly, IFIO therapists use tracking to assess a couple's predictable, repetitive, negative interactions.

Although couples often believe that one of them has "started" a fight and is to blame, we use the technique of tracking to shine light on process and move the conversation off the content of any given disagreement. While the couple's quarreling protectors want to discuss what happened this time and who's to blame, the relevant question is what happens every time they get into conflict and why their protective parts keep doing this regardless of content. To call attention to the feelings and needs underneath painful interactions, we not only unpack the couple's external, *interpersonal* dynamics, we also unpack their internal, *intrapersonal* dynamics, which motivate protectors. As long as protectors keep activating over the course of therapy, we track their interactions.

TRACKING

- Differentiates parts from the Self
- Helps partners notice protector reactivity in the form of predictable sequences of negative interactions
- Reveals the feelings and needs of vulnerable parts, which fuel protective behavior
- Invites partners to try something new so they can experience a different outcome

To track a sequence effectively, we stick with the following roadmap. First, we listen carefully to the couple's interaction and get details about each partner's behavior ("What do you do or say to your partner?"). Although couples believe the content of their fight is important, we stick with tracking how they interact. Next, we interview protectors about their motives ("What is this part afraid would happen to you if it didn't get so angry on your behalf?" or "What does this part hope for?") to learn about their hopes, fears, and needs. Rather than telling people how they feel or what motivates their protectors, we invite a process of self-exploration.

Our motto is "Ask—don't tell." By exploring, we flesh out the cycle of their fights experientially and help them recognize the predictability and repetitive nature of their fights. In addition, we reflect back what we hear each partner saying and pay attention to their level of autonomic arousal. If it gets too high, we intervene.

Finally, we issue an invitation of possibility. That is, we invite partners to imagine being less reactive and having more choice in how they respond to each other:

- "What if, regardless of your partner's reaction, you could stay centered and speak for what you want and need?"
- "What if you were less reactive, friendlier, and felt you had more choices about how to respond in these important conversations?"
- "If we could do something together to help both of you to be less reactive, feel more empowered, and have more hopeful interactions, would you be interested?"
- "If I could help each of you have more choice in how you respond when you hit communication snags, would you be interested?"

While tracking the couple's interactions, we also present them with four U-turn questions that were designed to help them listen carefully inside and learn from their parts. These particular questions are a subset of the larger number of U-turn questions we illustrate throughout the manual. To help partners answer, we explain each question. (The explanations offered here were developed by IFIO trainer Kate Lingren.)

1. "When your partner does X, what happens inside you?"

- Explanation: "Your reactivity comes from your vulnerability. If I can help each of you feel less vulnerable and less reactive, you will be aware that you have choices, both

individually and together. Rather than focusing on your partner, I will help each of you focus inside, on your vulnerability and on how your parts try to stay safe. I will especially do this in the beginning of therapy.”

2. “And then what do you notice in your body?”

- Explanation: “I ask you to notice what’s happening physically when your partner does X because that helps us locate reactive parts who need your help.”

3. “What is your first impulse?”

- Explanation: “I ask you to notice your first impulse because protective parts react to perceived threats by fleeing, fighting, or freezing. When you notice parts who react in one of these ways, they notice you. Noticing you is the first step a part can take to separate, or unblend, from you. As soon your parts unblend, you will feel more spacious, less pressured to respond quickly, better able to help them, and more curious about what other people are experiencing.”

4. “What do you hear yourself saying to yourself about you, your partner, or this relationship?”

- Explanation: “I ask what you hear yourself saying about yourself and other people because protective parts try to keep us safe by telling us stories. Though they mean well, their stories are usually colored by past experience and can seriously distort our view of the present. Our aim here is to befriend your storytelling parts and solve this underlying problem of feeling unsafe so they don’t have to work so hard.”

These questions help protectors who have intense feelings to unblend so partners can regulate their ANS and speak their truth without attacking or collapsing.

TRACKING PATTERNS OF CONFLICT

Jane and Doran were a cisgendered, lesbian, African-American couple in their mid fifties. They had been together for 18 years and married for 10. Jane had a teenage son with a previous partner who lived with them part time. But by choice they had no children together. Both were employed as health care practitioners.

The following dialogue between Jane and Doran illustrates how to track the sequence of a couple’s conflict.

Jane: [chuckles] Maybe you can fix her today.

Doran: She may be joking, but she does think I need to be fixed. [*turning to Jane*] All I really want, Jane, is more time with you.

Jane: What do you mean? I spend a lot of time with you. But remember, I earn most of the money and we're over our heads in debt.

Therapist: [*to Jane*] When Doran said, "I want more time with you," what happened inside you?

Asking a U-turn question that invites Jane to be curious about her reaction to Doran

Jane: I guess I got defensive.

Therapist: I'm going to restate that as "A part of me got defensive," okay?

Sticking to parts language

Jane: What difference does it make?

Therapist: I think it'll make a big difference, but let's try it out and you can tell me if I'm right.

Opting for showing rather than telling

Jane: Okay. A part of me got defensive.

Therapist: What are you noticing in your body?

Anchoring the target part

Jane: My chest is tight. I notice anger.

Therapist: And what do you hear yourself saying to yourself?

Helping the partners listen for vulnerability or projection

Jane: I never get it right for her.

Therapist: Feeling you never get it right. I imagine this is hard or painful.

*Validating and being curious about
underlying feelings*

Jane: Yes, it is.

Therapist: It sounds to me like you feel angry and defensive. Any other feelings?

*Making time for the client to continue to
check inside*

Jane: [pausing] I feel hurt.

Therapist: I think I am hearing several parts. Let me see if I get this right. Angry, defensive, and hurt, and some part that says, “I can’t get it right.”

*Reflecting, giving an overview, and
checking again for agreement or
disagreement*

Jane: Yes, that’s right.

Therapist: And when all this is happening inside you, what do you do or say to Doran?

Detailing behaviors

Jane: I just want to get out of there.

Therapist: And do you go away?

Jane: I notice I stay at work longer, or sometimes when I get home, I just go up to my office and get on the computer.

Therapist: It sounds like you withdraw.

Jane: I do.

Therapist: [to Doran] Are you aware of the part of Jane who withdraws?

Doran: I certainly am.

Therapist: And when Jane’s parts are taking her away, what happens inside you?

Asking a U-turn question to invite curiosity

Doran: I hate to admit it, but I get angry and loud.

Jane: [interrupts] She gets critical.

Therapist: [to Jane] I'm going to ask you to wait so I can listen to Doran for a few minutes. Actually, I'm going to ask both of you to hold off on speaking while the other person is talking. Can we agree to that for now?

Contracting for safety

Jane: Okay, okay. It's hard.

Therapist: I understand how hard it is given where you are. Thank you for doing something hard.

*Validating protective response while
maintaining the boundary*

Therapist: [to Doran] So you have a part who gets loud?

Sticking to parts language

Doran: Yes, loud, and I hate to admit it, demanding.

Therapist: What happens in your body when you get loud and demanding? And what do you hear yourself saying to yourself?

Asking U-turn questions

Doran: I have to admit that I hear myself wondering: *What's wrong with me? Why does Jane avoid me?*

Therapist: Are you aware of that part right now?

Doran: Yes, I have a lump in my stomach. I feel bad.

Therapist: Let's connect with it for a moment and find out more.

Doran: I don't like feeling this way.

Therapist: This makes a lot of sense to me, Doran. Just like Jane, it sounds like you have a couple of active parts in these interactions. One part gets loud and demanding and the other says: *What's wrong with me that Jane is avoiding me?* Am I getting that right?

Validating, mirroring, and checking for agreement

Doran: Yes, you've got it.

Therapist: And it sounds like there might be a relationship between these two parts of you. The bigger that lump in your stomach gets, the louder and more demanding your frustrated part becomes? [*Doran nods*] Okay. I want to ask both of you a question. I'll start with you, Doran, to get a sense of this part who gets loud and demanding. What might happen if it didn't do that?

Doran: [*pausing*] I'd never get her attention. We'd stay disconnected and I'd never get my needs met.

Therapist: So, this part of you is trying to be connected with Jane?

Doran: Yes. I guess it is. But it doesn't really work, does it?

Therapist: [*to Jane*] Did you know this?

Jane: Of course not. I just feel criticized.

Therapist: And what about the part of you who withdraws. Are you aware of it right now?

Jane: I can still feel it, but I feel less guarded hearing what Doran just said.

Therapist: And what might that part be concerned about? What if it let you stay and not withdraw?

Jane: [*pausing*] I would just keep being criticized.

Therapist: And then what?

Jane: I would keep feeling misunderstood.

Therapist: And then what?

Jane: More hurt.

Therapist: I imagine the part who feels hurt would rather feel appreciated, like you are doing enough and being successful. I think that's what I heard. Am I right?

Jane: You're right!

Therapist: I want to reflect back what I'm hearing from both of you. This sounds like a dilemma related to needs. Jane, when Doran tries to have more time with you and her parts get loud and demanding, as she describes it, you have a part who feels hurt, like you can't get it right. Then you withdraw to protect yourself. And Doran, when Jane withdraws, you feel bad and disconnected, and then you try to get her attention by getting louder and more demanding to protect yourself. And it goes on like this, back and forth with each of you feeling more protected but less connected. Does this sound like the pattern?

Naming the sequence and the patterns of reaction and counterreaction

Doran: It's the pattern for sure.

Jane: [*nods in agreement*] It feels hopeless. We're really stuck.

Therapist: I understand that this cycle causes you to feel hopeless, and you would break the pattern if you could. I have a question for you. If I could help each of you to have many more choices in how to respond when you feel reactive, would that be good? [*they nod*] And if you could understand what your protective parts are hoping for, would that be good? [*they nod*] And, finally, if I could help you shift this pattern of reaction and counterreaction, would you be interested?

Issuing the invitation of possibility

Jane: I'm interested. How about you, Doran?

Doran: I would certainly be interested. I hate being at odds all the time.



We want couples to slow down and focus on their process rather than the content of their disagreements. The following worksheet, **Who Am I in a Conflict?** is designed to help couples track their patterns of conflict. The more separation partners get from their protectors and the more

they see how their protectors contribute to the problem, the more they understand the relationship of all this protection to their own vulnerability.

Client Worksheet**WHO AM I IN A CONFLICT?**
THE SEQUENCE TRACKING WORKSHEET

Tracking sets the stage for a U-turn and reveals the protectors who engage in conflict. By becoming familiar with how they engage in arguments, you will, right away, begin the process of breaking uncomfortable patterns of fighting.

1. As you watched your partner say or do whatever it is that triggers your protectors, what did you notice?

What happened in your body?

What did you hear yourself saying to yourself?

Were you aware of any feeling(s)? If so, which ones?

What was your first impulse?

2. What did you do or say in relationship to that person?

3. What response did you get back?

4. How did you react to that?

5. What did you notice as you stepped back and allowed yourself to see this cycle of reaction and counterreaction?

6. What did you learn about:

Your protector's job or role?

Your protector's wish for you?

How long it has had this job?

What it fears about not responding in this way?

Who it protects?

7. How did your protector respond to your invitation to be in relationship with you in this moment?

Courageous Communication: Change Your Conversation to Change Your Relationship

Couples benefit from learning to speak and listen well. Brain science tells us that empathic communication rewires the brain (Siegel, 2007) and supports changes in patterned behavior. Empathic communication means “feeling with” someone else without getting overwhelmed by their feelings. When we empathize, we feel with—but we don’t confuse ourselves with—the other person: “I can imagine what’s happening for you and resonate with your feelings. Though I know I’m not you, I have these feelings sometimes too.” When we feel compassion for someone else, we care and feel concerned. We want couples to be able to empathize with and feel compassion for each other. In IFIO, we help partners maintain a self-other distinction inside and out so they can empathize safely

and feel compassion for each other. Feeling known and understood initiates a positive cycle of connection and caring because it feels so good.

That said, staying curious and open-minded while listening to someone who feels hurt and angry describe the impact of your behavior takes willingness and courage. Speaking and listening well, which both require physiological regulation, call for a level of skill and patience that many couples have not had the opportunity to cultivate. On the other side of the fence, speaking about the other's impact truthfully without attacking, collapsing, or panicking also takes courage. Good communication requires both partners to stay in the conversation until everyone feels heard and understood, but when protectors feel threatened by differences, they can behave in ways that are far from ideal.

For example, a protector may refuse to listen because